

Split Yellow Bus Initiative

Redistributing Pupils from Overcrowded Eastern Schools to Under-Enrolled Central Schools

Date: May 2026
City: Split, Croatia
School level: Elementary (OŠ), Grades 1–8

1. Executive Summary

Split’s primary schools are in a state of structural imbalance. Schools in the rapidly growing eastern neighbourhoods are operating at—or beyond—the legal limit of the Croatian Pedagogical Standard, with two schools still running **3 shifts per day**, a condition not envisioned in Croatian education law as a permanent arrangement. Meanwhile, schools in the historic city centre and western Split are operating at **40–60% of their single-shift capacity**, with classrooms sitting empty each afternoon.

The standard government response—building 2–3 new schools in the east—is estimated to take until **2030 at the earliest** and require hundreds of millions of HRK in capital expenditure. The City of Split has already committed €18.2M of NPOO (EU Recovery Fund) money to expand three eastern schools, which will help but will not resolve the imbalance alone.

This paper proposes a complementary, faster, and significantly cheaper intervention: a **dedicated school bus service (“Yellow Bus”)** that transports a defined number of pupils from overcrowded eastern schools to willing under-enrolled central schools each day, on a voluntary opt-in basis.

Key enabler: Since September 2025, the City of Split provides **free public transport** to all pupils with Split residency. The Yellow Bus would extend this principle with a dedicated, reliable vehicle — not a policy leap, but a logical next step on infrastructure already in place.

2. The Problem: A Tale of Two Cities

2.1 Enrollment Data

School	Neighbourhood	Est. Enrollment	Shifts	Sections	Status
OŠ Mejaši	Eastern Split	~926	3 (lower) / 2 (upper)	39	Critical

School	Neighbourhood	Est. Enrollment	Shifts	Sections	Status
OŠ Ravne Njive	Eastern Split	Large / unknown	3	~28+	Critical
OŠ Sućidar	Eastern Split	~700	2	3–4 per grade	Strained
OŠ Mertojak	Eastern Split	~540–659	2 (was 3)	Multiple	Strained
OŠ Plokite	West/Centre	~445	1	—	Underused
OŠ Lučac	City Centre	391	2 (alternating)	23	Underused
OŠ Dobri	Historic Centre	~264	1 (likely)	—	Underused
OŠ Meje	Western Split	~362	1–2	2 per grade	Underused

Gap: Mejaši alone enrolls more pupils than Dobri, Meje, and Plokite combined.

2.2 The Three-Shift School: An Illegal Normality

Croatian **Državni pedagoški standard** (NN 63/2008, amended NN 90/2010) sets out:

- **Maximum sections per school:** 32 (enabling 2-shift operation)
- **Three-shift operation:** Not defined as a permanent operating model — exists only as a tolerated transitional exception
- **Class size maximum:** 28 pupils; exceptions up to 34 only where there is a single section of that grade
- **OŠ Mejaši has 39 sections in 17 classrooms** — 7 sections above the 2-shift ceiling, requiring a 3rd shift to physically accommodate all classes

For OŠ Ravne Njive, it was reported as **one of only two schools in all of Croatia** still operating in 3 shifts as of 2022. This is not a local quirk — it is a national anomaly.

2.3 What 3-Shift Schooling Means in Practice

- **Lower-grade children** (ages 6–10) start school as late as **15:00**, returning home at 19:00
- Extracurricular activities, sports, cultural programmes are effectively impossible for afternoon-shift pupils
- Teachers work fragmented schedules across 3 sub-groups, reducing coordination and planning quality
- School facilities (libraries, labs, gyms) cannot serve all pupils adequately
- Parents in dual-income households face a childcare vacuum outside school hours

3. The Root Cause: Demographic Asymmetry

Split's eastern quarters grew explosively from the 1970s onward — Ravne Njive settlement alone grew to **over 9,000 residents**. New residential construction in Kila, Dragovode, and Neslanovac continues today.

Meanwhile, the historic city centre (Dobri, Lučac) and western Split (Meje, Plokite) follow the pan-European trend of aging populations, higher property prices, and smaller household sizes. Young families simply cannot afford or choose not to live in these areas — but the schools remain.

This demographic trajectory will not self-correct. Without intervention, eastern schools will continue to enroll more pupils through the 2030s while central schools slowly shrink further.

4. The Current Government Response and Its Limits

4.1 NPOO Investment (EU Recovery Funds)

The City of Split has secured **€18.2 million** from the National Recovery and Resilience Plan (NPOO) to expand three schools:

School	Planned Works	Target
OŠ Ravne Njive – Neslanovac	+14 classrooms, +8 subject labs	Single-shift + all-day school
OŠ Pujanke	Expansion and modernisation	Single-shift
OŠ Split 3	Expansion and modernisation	Single-shift

Additionally, a further **€16.5M** has been committed for the next wave of reconstruction.

4.2 Why This Is Not Enough

- Construction timelines: **2027–2030** at best, contingent on procurement, permits, and execution
- OŠ Mejaši is **not** among the NPOO beneficiary schools — its relief depends on a new school being built on the Kila site, a project with no confirmed timeline or funding
- Construction addresses supply (more classrooms in the east) but does not address the paradox of **empty classrooms sitting 5 km away** in the west
- The NPOO expansion at Ravne Njive adds 14 classrooms — but the school needs approximately 20–22 to function on a single shift at current enrollment
- EU funds come with conditions: scope is fixed, repurposing is not straightforward

4.3 The Single-Shift Target

The Croatian Ministry of Education has stated a national target of **eliminating multi-shift schooling** by approximately 2030. For Split, the city itself has acknowledged this is contingent on **2–3 new schools** being built in eastern Split — schools that are still in the planning stage.

5. The Yellow Bus Proposal

5.1 Core Concept

A dedicated school bus service that, **on a voluntary opt-in basis**, transports a defined cohort of pupils from overcrowded eastern schools to under-enrolled central schools each morning, and returns them in the afternoon.

The service targets primarily **lower grades (1–4)**, where 3-shift operation is most acute, where parental escorts are already common, and where pupils are less rigidly tied to peer networks at a single school.

5.2 How It Would Work

07:30 Bus departs from Mejaši / Ravne Njive pick-up point
08:00 Arrives at OŠ Dobri / OŠ Meje / OŠ Lučac
08:00 School day begins (single shift, standard timetable)
13:00 Bus departs from receiving school
13:30 Pupils returned to eastern Split drop-off point

- **Route:** Eastern pick-up (near school) → Central school → Return
- **Capacity per bus:** 50–55 pupils (standard coach)
- **Phase 1 target:** 2 buses, 100–110 pupils per direction
- **Schools served (sending):** OŠ Mejaši, OŠ Ravne Njive
- **Schools served (receiving):** OŠ Dobri, OŠ Meje, OŠ Lučac

5.3 Impact on Overcrowded Schools

Transferring 100 pupils from OŠ Mejaši (926 pupils, 39 sections) would: - Allow elimination of approximately **3–4 sections** from the lower grades - Reduce total sections from 39 to ~35–36, moving below the 2-shift operational ceiling (32) - Enable conversion of lower grades to **2 shifts** as an immediate interim measure - Reduce class sizes toward the 20-pupil optimal (from the current ~26–28 per section)

For OŠ Ravne Njive, whose NPOO expansion is approved but not yet built, transferring 50 pupils buys relief during the 2–4 year construction window.

5.4 Impact on Receiving Schools

School	Current Enrollment	Spare Capacity (1-shift)	After receiving 25–35 pupils
OŠ Dobri	~264	~200+	Still well within capacity
OŠ Meje	~362	~100–150	Comfortably within capacity
OŠ Lučac	391	~100	Within capacity

No expansion required. No new teachers required beyond existing staff ratios — these schools currently have teachers with underutilised hours.

6. Why Now: Three Enabling Conditions

6.1 Free Public Transport Already Exists

Since **September 2025**, the City of Split provides free city bus passes to all pupils with Split residency. The city has already crossed the political Rubicon of publicly-funded pupil transport. A Yellow Bus is the dedicated, reliable, school-timed version of a principle already in law and in practice.

Cost implication: The marginal political cost of the Yellow Bus is much lower than it would have been pre-2025.

6.2 Receiving Schools Have Capacity and Incentive

OŠ Dobri (264 pupils), OŠ Meje (362 pupils), and OŠ Lučac (391 pupils) all face a long-term demographic decline. Additional enrolled pupils: - Improve per-pupil state funding (capitation grants flow with the child) - Justify maintaining or expanding teaching staff - Improve the school's position in any future rationalisation decisions - Enrich classroom diversity and peer-group size

School directors in the centre have an institutional interest in cooperating.

6.3 NPOO Construction Provides the Long-Term Fix

The Yellow Bus is not a permanent solution — it is a **bridge measure** that buys 3–5 years while NPOO-funded expansion is completed. This framing is politically easier to sell: it is not “busing children away from their neighbourhood schools permanently,” it is “easing overcrowding while we build the infrastructure that fixes it properly.”

7. Cost Estimate

7.1 Capital Costs

Item	Est. Cost	Notes
2 dedicated buses (purchased)	€180,000–€240,000	Standard 50-seat school coach
Alternatively: leased from operator	—	See operating costs
GPS / communication equipment	€5,000	Per vehicle
Bus stop infrastructure (if needed)	€10,000–€20,000	Eastern pick-up points

7.2 Annual Operating Costs

Item	Est. Annual Cost
Driver salaries (2 drivers × full-time)	€40,000–€50,000
Fuel (2 buses × ~60 km/day × 180 school days)	€15,000–€20,000
Maintenance and insurance	€10,000–€15,000
Administration / coordination	€5,000
Total annual operating cost	~€70,000–€90,000/year

7.3 Comparison: The Alternative

Building **one new school** in eastern Split: - Estimated cost: **€8–15 million** (based on comparable Croatian school construction) - Timeline: 5–8 years from planning to occupancy - Annual maintenance: additional operating budget

The Yellow Bus costs ~€90,000/year — less than **1% of the cost of a new school** — while providing immediate relief during the construction gap.

Even if the Yellow Bus operates for 5 years as a bridge, total cost is ~€500,000 (including purchase). Compared to €10M+ for a new school, this is a 95%+ cost saving for interim relief.

8. Addressing Concerns

8.1 “Parents won’t agree to send young children across the city”

- Participation is **entirely voluntary** — no family is compelled
- Lower grades already have accompanied pick-up by parents; the bus stop serves as the rendezvous point

- The route is short (Split is compact — eastern schools to the centre is 5–8 km)
- Incentive: children transfer to a **single-shift school**, meaning they are home by 13:30 instead of 19:00

8.2 “Children should attend their neighbourhood school”

- Croatian law does not mandate catchment-area enrollment — parents already have the right to enroll children in any school
- The Yellow Bus does not displace neighbourhood children — it provides an **option** to families who choose quality-of-education (single shift, smaller class) over proximity
- Neighbourhood identity is built in residential areas, not school buildings

8.3 “This is a Band-Aid, not a real solution”

- Correct — it is explicitly a **bridge measure**, not a substitute for construction
- The NPOO programme already provides the structural solution; the Yellow Bus provides interim relief
- The Croatian Ministry of Education’s 2030 single-shift target needs all tools available — building alone will not be sufficient in time

8.4 “Logistical complexity”

- Split is a compact city; eastern schools to central schools is a 15-minute drive
- Promet Split already operates coordinated transit in the city — operational expertise exists
- A phased pilot (1 bus, 1 route, 1 receiving school) limits initial complexity

9. Implementation Roadmap

Phase 1 — Pilot (Academic Year 2026/27)

Milestone	Timeline
City council decision and budget allocation	Jun–Sep 2026
School director agreements (Mejaši + Dobri/Meje)	Sep 2026
Voluntary enrollment open to lower-grade families at Mejaši	Sep–Oct 2026
Bus procurement or lease contract	Oct 2026
Pilot launch: 1 bus, 1 route, ~50 pupils	Jan 2027
Mid-year evaluation	Jun 2027

Phase 2 — Scale (Academic Year 2027/28)

Milestone	Timeline
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Milestone	Timeline
Add second bus and route (Ravne Njive → Lučac/Meje)	Sep 2027
Expand to upper primary grades (5–8) if demand exists	Sep 2027
Integration with NPOO construction schedule review	Ongoing

Phase 3 — Review and Transition

Milestone	Timeline
NPOO-funded expansions complete	2028–2030
Reassess redistribution need vs. new capacity	2029
Wind down or repurpose buses as construction relieves pressure	2030

10. Stakeholder Map

Stakeholder	Position	Action Required
City of Split (Grad Split)	Key decision-maker	Budget, political will, coordination
Ministry of Education (MZO)	Regulatory authority	Approval for cross-catchment enrollment mechanism
School Directors (eastern)	Likely supportive — relieves pressure	Cooperation, identification of volunteer families
School Directors (central)	Likely supportive — gains enrollment	Cooperation, capacity confirmation
Parents (eastern schools)	Voluntary participants	Informed consent, opt-in
Promet Split	Potential operator	Operational delivery, driver supply
Croatian media	Amplifier	Already covers 3-shift schools negatively — framing opportunity

11. Precedents

- **United States:** The school bus system is the backbone of public education redistribution, transporting ~26 million children daily. The model originated specifically to equalize access across geography.
- **Germany (Schulbus):** Rural and suburban dedicated buses are standard; some Länder use redistribution to manage enrollment imbalances between schools.

- **Zagreb, Croatia:** School transport exists for certain rural-to-urban routes; no precedent for intra-urban redistribution — **Split would be first in Croatia.**
- **Split 2025:** Free universal student public transport already introduced — the political and administrative precedent for city-funded pupil transport exists locally.

12. Recommendations

Short term (2026): 1. Commission a formal feasibility study (route, capacity, demand survey among Mejaši and Ravne Njive families) 2. Open dialogue with directors of OŠ Dobri and OŠ Meje on capacity and willingness 3. Include Yellow Bus as a line item in the 2027 city education budget

Medium term (2027–2028): 4. Launch pilot with 1 bus, voluntary opt-in, lower grades only 5. Monitor and publish impact metrics: class sizes, shift reduction, parental satisfaction 6. Present pilot results to Ministry of Education as a model for other Croatian cities

Long term (2029–2030): 7. Evaluate continuation, expansion, or phase-out as NPOO construction completes 8. Document lessons learned for national policy

13. Key Messages (for Presentation)

“Split has two school systems in one city.”

Eastern children start school at 15:00 and return home in the dark. Central schools have empty classrooms every afternoon.

“We don’t need to wait for new schools. We need to use what we have.”

OŠ Dobri, Meje, and Lučac have capacity for hundreds more pupils — today, not in 2030.

“The bus already exists — it just doesn’t have yellow paint.”

Split already pays for all pupils to travel on public transport. A dedicated school bus is the same principle, with a timetable that matches the school day.

“One bus, 50 children, €90,000 per year.”

That is less than 1% of the cost of one new school. It can start in January 2027.

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